

Recollections of Søren Kierkegaard

[Erindringer om Søren Kierkegaard]

Hans Brøchner

Det nittende Aarhundrede. Maanedsskrift for Literatur og Kritik, vol. 5,
March 1877, pp. 337–374

Translated from the Danish

I have wanted to write down some of the recollections I have of Søren Kierkegaard from a long run of years, and which might be of some interest to others as well. They might perhaps one day, when S. K. finds a competent biographer, help to make his portrait in certain respects more finished and more alive. I write down my recollections precisely as material for a portrait of K., and therefore without any attempt, at this stage, to work them up into a whole or to give them a rounded finish by gathering them into groups. They are given just as they have been preserved, after the first impression, as *separate* memories in a faithful memory.

1.

My first meeting with S. K. falls in the very earliest days after I had become a student (1836). I saw him then in the house of my old uncle, the wholesale merchant M. A. Kierkegaard, at a party given on the occasion of the present Bishop Kierkegaard's engagement (or wedding?) to his first wife. I saw S. K. there without knowing who he was; I had only been told that he was Dr. K.'s brother. He spoke only very little that evening; he kept, I believe, essentially to observing. I received only a definite impression of his exterior, which rather amused me. He was then 23 years old, had something very irregular about his whole figure and a remarkable coiffure. His hair rose in a tousled crest nearly six inches above his forehead, and it gave him a strangely wild look. I got the idea, without my knowing how, that he was a merchant's clerk — perhaps because the family was a family of merchants — and under the impression of his odd exterior I at once completed it: he must be in a draper's shop. I have often laughed heartily since at my own acumen.

2.

Then I remember, in the time just after, now and then having seen S. K. at the same place. I now came to talk with him, and soon noticed that he belonged somewhere other than behind a counter with the ell-measure in his hand. Amid the very plain surroundings there he amused himself by putting forward little paradoxes. Thus I remember that he once astonished his relatives by declaring, with the most serious face in the world, that he found the old A. B. C. we used in our childhood to be one of the most interesting books there were, and that he still read in it quite regularly, and got much profit from it.

— One evening he joined in a game of boston. It was played there with variations, one of which consisted in this, that 3 of the players were dealt 17 cards each, the fourth, on the other hand, only one, and that the 3 others then each gave up 4 cards to the last. In that house, where card-playing was taken with devout seriousness, the situation of the 4th man in this game was always regarded as most lamentable, and S. K. again caused great astonishment by expounding that it was the most excellent situation that could be imagined, and that his only wish was always to be able to be the fourth man so situated. That would be the most piquant thing of all.

3.

In 1837 I met K. now and then at a restaurant. He no longer lived with his father [339] at that time, but in a house in Løvstræde, I believe the one where Reitzel's bookshop now (1871) is. He usually took his supper at a restaurant, and I can remember that I, when I now and then treated myself to "a half boeuf," was astonished at the luxury S. K. displayed when he took his supper with a half bottle of wine and the like. We now talked together more frequently, and he showed himself very kind toward me. One evening he asked me what I was reading in the way of aesthetic writings. On that occasion I came to mention that I had access to only a little, and that I was quite unacquainted with many fields. He asked me whether I knew the writings of the German Romantics, and I had to say that I did not. He then urged me to come home with him and lent me a book by Eichendorff: *Dichter und ihre Gesellen*, — a book I later bought at the auction of his books in remembrance of this meeting with him. I then remember that when, after a fortnight or so, I brought it back to him, and was just about to make an excuse because I, who at that time was studying theology with passion, had kept it so long, I was disconcerted when he received me with the question whether I had *already* read it. He had evidently, with his sharp eye, been able to see that the opposite word was hovering on my tongue, and he amused himself by embarrassing me in a good-natured way; which at that time was exceedingly easy. I blushed so easily, and that sight always appealed to him in "the young person." — From my visit to K., when he lent me the book, I remember two things. One is my astonishment at his large library, which quite impressed me. The other was a peculiarity of K.'s. He went out again when we had fetched the book, and, as we were leaving, blew out a wax candle he had lit. He explained [340] to me then that he always did it with a certain caution and at some distance, because he had reflected himself into the notion that the smoke of the candle was dangerous to inhale and could harm his chest.

3.

In 1838 S. K.'s father died. Him I saw only once, at my old uncle Kierkegaard's. He was a considerable personality, whose outward appearance imprinted itself vividly on my memory. He was walking up and down the floor of my uncle's dining room with him, in conversation. He walked somewhat stooped; his bearing matched the thoughtful, serious expression of his face; the gray hair was brushed back behind the ear, so that the form of the face stood out sharply. — The reverence and love S. K. bore his father have found their living expression in his writings. — The old man was a very punctual man, exact in money matters, thrifty in everyday things, but openhanded when occasion offered. S. K. once told me how he, as a young student, had made a journey in Nordsjælland, and how the old man had fitted him out generously with travel money, and then had even surprised him by sending him, at one of the last stages of the journey, a registered letter with 50 rix-dollars. Of his father's punctuality S. K. once, in a conversation with Mag. Adler, used the expression: "my father was born on quarter day." — When S. K. left his father's house, the old man gave him yearly a sum that was very ample by the standards of the time; if I am not much mistaken, it was 800 rix-dollars a year.

5.

My late sister Hansine was in town in 1839 as a young girl. Once, when I happened to mention S. K., she told me that she had seen him when, before her confirmation, she [341] was here in town on a visit to old Uncle Kierkegaard. Our cousins had one day, when S. K. was to come there, given her the advice not to have anything to do with him, since he was "a dreadfully spoiled and naughty boy, who always clung to his mother's skirts." My sister was then 13 years old, S. K. 15. Later she read with great pleasure some of his upbuilding writings, especially "Works of Love," and could then sometimes, with the smile peculiar to her, remind me of the cousins' admonition to her.

6.

Shortly after S. K. had taken his theological degree in 1840, I talked with him. He told me that his father had constantly wished him to take the theological examination, and that they had very often discussed the matter. "As long as Father was alive, I could nevertheless defend my theory that I ought not to take it, but when he was dead, and I also had to take over his *partes* in the debate, then I could no longer hold my own, and so I had to make up my mind to read for the examination." This S. K. had then done with great energy. He had taken "Sin Brøchner" as his coach, had worked his way through

the driest disciplines, made excerpts from church history, learned “the lists of popes” by heart and the like. His coach was very pleased with him. Shortly after S. K. had taken the examination, Peter Stilling (later Dr. phil.) came to Sin Brøchner and wanted to be coached. He remarked that he thought he could be finished in a year and a half; “S. K. hadn’t read any longer than that, after all.” “Oh, to be sure,” said old Br., who did not excel in politeness, “don’t you go imagining that! with S. K. it was another matter, he could do anything!” — I remember that in 1839 I attended theological writing exercises together with S. K. under Clausen. He took part in them, however, only for the first 2 or 3 sessions. It was told that he had once, several years earlier, taken part in Clausen’s writing exercises and once, instead of answering the set question, had analyzed it and [342] shown that there was no sense to be found in it. At this Cl. had been offended, and S. K. had stopped going to the writing exercises. — At the written theological examination S. K. was placed No. 4 in the grading. Ahead of him stood M. Wad, Warburg and Chr. F. Christens. The examiners, however, declared to these that K.’s papers bore witness to a far greater maturity and development of thought than any of the others’; but theirs contained a richer measure of positive theological matter.

7.

In the same conversation in which S. K. told me how he had come to take the theological examination, he also spoke of his father’s remarkable calm and objectivity. Thus the old man had once said to S. K.: “it would really be a stroke of luck for you if I were dead; then perhaps you might still amount to something; you will not, as long as I live.” — (Another trait of his father was told me by my late cousin Peter Kierkegaard. When S. K.’s mother died, his father was deeply grieved. At the funeral Bishop Mynster came up to him and, moved, expressed his sympathy. The old man listened to Mynster, whom he esteemed highly, without betraying his grief, and when Mynster fell silent, he said: “Shall we not then, Your Right Reverence, go into the room there and drink a glass of wine.” Mynster, who knew him, did not misunderstand this remark.)

8.

It was while S. K. was in Berlin in 1841–42 that I presented myself for the theological examination, to which, on account of my unorthodox views, I was refused admission. I was corresponding at that time with Chr. F. Christens, who was also in Berlin, and through him I sent and received greetings, also to and from Kierkegaard. Shortly after his return home I met him in the street. He was very friendly toward me, talked about [343]

my situation and my studies, and told me, which pleased me, that in Berlin he had longed for several things back home, among them also to see me. Such a thing he could say with a peculiarly winning expression. His smile and his glance were indescribably expressive. He had a way of his own of greeting at a distance with a glance. It was only a small movement of the eye, and yet it expressed so much. There could be something infinitely gentle and loving in his glance, but also something provoking and teasing. He could, with one glance at a passer-by, irresistibly “put himself in rapport” with him, as he put it. Whoever met this glance was either attracted or repelled, made embarrassed, uncertain or irritated. I have walked the whole length of a street with him while he expounded to me how, by thus putting oneself in rapport with passers-by, one could make psychological studies, and while he expounded the theory, he put it into practice with nearly every person we met. There was not one on whom his glance did not make a visible impression. On the same occasion he astonished me by the ease with which he struck up a conversation with any number of people, in a few exchanges took up an earlier conversation and carried it a step further to a point where it could be taken up again on occasion. The occasion for these experiments was that one day I had been walking ahead of him, absorbed in thought, so that I had not heard him calling me, and had not noticed him tapping me on the shoulder. When I finally noticed him, he said that one did wrong thus to sink into oneself and not to make the observations one could make in such rich measure. Then, to show me the method, he pulled me along with him up and down several streets, and astonished me with his talent for psychological experiment. He was always interesting to walk with, but in one respect walking with [344] him had its difficulty. Because of the irregularity of his movements, which was no doubt connected with his crookedness, one could never keep to a straight line when walking with him; one was always pushed, little by little, in toward the houses and the cellar steps, or out toward the gutter. When he, in addition, gestured with his arm and his cane, it became even more of a march over obstacles. One had now and then to seize an opportunity to get round to his other side in order to gain the room one needed.

9.

The winter S. K. spent in Berlin, he met there many Danes, not a few of whom had come there to hear Schelling. Among them was my late friend Christian Fenger Christens. Of him S. K. spoke with great appreciation; he stated later to me that Christens was the ablest of all the Danes who had been in Berlin that winter, and among them were, after all, such men as Lic. jur. (later Minister) A. F. Krieger, and the judge advocate (now head of department in the Ministry of Church and Education) Carl Weiss. Christens told me

various little traits of K., of his helplessness when he had to speak German, especially when he had to speak of things of daily life (thus on the first evening in Berlin it was not possible for him to make it understood that he wanted a candlestick); — of how his landlord overcharged him and, as the overcharging grew, by way of compensation let him advance from Magister to Doctor and then to Professor; — something Kierkegaard himself was amused at, since he no doubt guessed the reason, — of his embarrassment when Weiss, who set store by an elegant dinner, had one day taken him into a first-class restaurant, where a number of elegantly dressed gentlemen in black coats, with white neckcloths and cravats, stood in the corners of the room, and after K. had respectfully greeted them and sat down at a table with W., came leaping up and turned out to be [345] waiters etc. — Christens also told me how Kierkegaard in Berlin amused himself by getting Lic. theol. * onto slippery ground. * had already been abroad for a long time, had heard lectures in Strasburg and elsewhere and was very self-important on account of all the wisdom he had gathered. S. K. seldom failed, when they met, to ask him to share with him the most essential scientific results of his journey abroad. When * then formulated some proposition or other as a result gained, K. always knew how either to show him that it was something very old, or, by asking little questions about “something that was not quite clear to him” in what had been put forward, to bring the poor licentiate, who was only slightly gifted as a thinker, into such confusion that he did not know which way to turn. When K. had then got him to that point, it suddenly occurred to him that he was very busy and absolutely had to go somewhere or other. Then he left the licentiate standing in the midst of the confusion, to the great amusement of the others. — In K.’s Either/Or this method is depicted, applied precisely to a licentiate. Might he not have had his Berlin acquaintance in mind when he wrote those pages?

10.

Not long after K.’s return home he once talked with me about my studies. I told him what Greek authors I was reading at the time, and touched on the interest that was awakening in me more and more for Greek poetry and philosophy. He encouraged me to continue these studies and spoke warmly of the significance of the Greek for our time. He used the expression: “Greece ought always to have a representative accredited to our time, just as one power has a representative accredited to another to make its interests felt.” — K. himself had a good knowledge of Greek and had read not a little. How finely [346] he apprehended the Greek spirit, his writings bear witness.

11.

In 1842 a small pseudonymous work appeared: “Johan Ludvig Heiberg efter Døden.” I knew of the work before it appeared, and mentioned it once to S. K. He was not pleased that Heiberg was made the object of such a joke, and spoke with much warmth of his importance as an aesthetician and especially as his generation’s teacher of aesthetics in our fatherland^{*)}. Later, after *Either/Or* had appeared, and Heiberg had written his well-known review of it, S. K. once spoke to me about him and made his displeasure at H.’s conduct plain to see. He acknowledged H.’s importance as an aesthetician, but now also strongly stressed his limitations. “I would be able to bring forward a whole series of aesthetic problems of which H. has not an inkling.” By this he was no doubt alluding to the problems that have come forward in “Stages on Life’s Way” and “Concluding Postscript.”

12.

In those years I frequently met S. K. when in the evening I went for a walk. As a rule Frederiksberg Have was the goal of my walk. K. too went that far, but only to the entrance of the garden, where the little flower beds are on either side of the path, narrow at that time, that leads from the gate to the first open space. There he breathed in for a [347] few moments the scent of the flowers, and then took the recollection of this “moment” away with him. That was how he liked to conclude and to set limits: his walk had a definite goal, but this goal was, as it were, only touched; he did not linger over it, and he took away, as it were, only a motif of enjoyment that could be worked up ideally.

A small comic recollection is attached to one of these evening walks. As we were going back from the garden to the avenue and had to pass between the posts that stand at the end of the path between the trees that is set aside for pedestrians, the posts had just been painted. K. did not notice this, but rested his hand on them as he passed between them. He then noticed that his hand was covered in paint, and now, while carrying on with his conversation, made a series of unsuccessful attempts, with the indispensable cane under his arm, to wash the paint off by rubbing the drooping leaves of the trees, damp with dew, between his hands. His exertions brought many a smile to the faces of the passers-by.

13.

At that time I also saw S. K. on horseback now and then. He had learned to ride so as to be able to take this exercise and to make short excursions independently of coachmen

^{*)}K. placed H. above all the contemporary aestheticians in Germany (NB. Vischer had not yet at that time come forward except with lesser things.)

and the like. He cut no very good figure on a horse. One could see from his posture that he did not credit himself with any great ability to control it, should it take it into its head to turn rebellious. He sat stiffly on the horse, and one had the impression that he was constantly remembering the riding master's instructions. He can hardly have had much freedom to pursue his thoughts and his fancies on horseback. And indeed he soon gave up this sport and preferred to drive when he wanted to visit his favorite spots in the woods around Copenhagen. In the years when his authorship was at its most intense, these outings were one of the means he used to keep himself fresh, and to bring himself [348] into the mood that the production demanded.

14.

One single expression of K.'s from that time I cite as characteristic. He had a servant who was very reliable and to whom K. entrusted the carrying out of all kinds of practical matters. Thus when he was to move house, he would drive out in the morning, and in the evening he would go home to his new apartment, where everything stood in perfect order — even the library had been arranged — with the servant's help. Of this servant K. once said, after speaking of his practical talent: "he is in reality *my body*."

15.

In the first period after *Either/Or* had come out, I had frequent conversations with him about the book. On reading through the Διαψάλλματα I had at once recognized the anonymous author; I had at once found words that had been spoken in earlier conversations with K. Naturally I never tried, in my conversations with K., to get him to speak as the author; but where something was obscure to me, I talked with him about it as with the elder who had the richer insight. In this way I received many a fuller elaboration, and he spoke about the book with a lack of reserve that he would hardly have shown had I been indiscreet. One point on which he dwelt several times was the poetic element in Part One. One day he explained with great liveliness how in many places the motif for a poem was given, but a motif that had surely been left unexecuted on purpose. Thus as an example he singled out the depiction of woman's beauty and said: "in each of these phrases: the little hand, the dainty foot, etc., there lies a motif for a sonnet." — Now and then he would hint at, as it were, the lines along which the [349] problems treated in *Either/Or* could be extended; but several of his hints only became really intelligible to me when the subsequent writings came out. — He was not insensible to appreciative remarks about the book's significance. I remarked one day that no book,

since I first read Hegel's Logic, had set my thoughts in motion as Either/Or had. This remark evidently pleased him. We were just standing at the door of his lodgings (on Nørregade) and were about to go our separate ways; as we parted, he kindly gave me his hand, with the smile I knew so well.

16.

When I had published my piece against Martensen ("Nogle Bemærkninger om Daaben"), K. talked with me about it. He was displeased with a review in Berlingske Avis which had tried to strike a superior tone and, with an assumed authority, meant as it were to crush the young author. I told him that I had really only been amused by the review, since its forced Christian piety took on a slightly comic tinge when one remembered that the anonymous article appeared in a paper edited by a Jew. — In my little piece K. singled out one particular remark that he would have wished left out; it was, I believe, where, with some mockery of Martensen's attempt to assert the freedom of the newborn child, I say that the only act of freedom that can be spoken of in the newborn child at baptism is that the child screams when it is doused with water. This remark, K. thought, looked flippant, and could easily be exploited by the ill-disposed.

17.

[350] K. mentioned Ludvig Feuerbach rather often in our conversations. It is on the strength of oral remarks of his that I have said in *Problemet om Tro og Viden* (p. 125) that there can be no doubt that it is Feuerbach whom K. had in view in a quotation cited there. He acknowledged in Feuerbach the clarity and sharpness with which he, precisely as one offended, had grasped Christianity; but he once stressed in a conversation that from Feuerbach's enthusiasm for nature, particularly from the pathos with which in *Wesen des Chr.* he speaks of the strengthening power of water, in the spiritual respect as well, he had received the impression not merely of a strong sensuality in F., but also of an enfeeblement through sensuality. He added: "this is an opinion that I shall naturally never utter in print; but I have not been able to ward off this impression, and there is something in Feuerbach's peculiar passionate pathos, and in his antipathy to Christianity, that becomes clearer to me through this conjecture." — This remark about F. led him to speak of figures from antiquity in whom a refined sensuality came to the fore. Thus he gave a very imaginatively executed picture of Mæcenas: how he, who "had no doubt exhausted all the pleasures of Rome," sought oblivion in his sleeplessness in the soft splashing of the fountain in his bedchamber and in faint strains of distant music. Such

pictures he could paint finely; yet it was not the poetic depiction, but the psychological analysis, or rather dissection, that interested him.

18.

On a longer walk in those years I once had occasion to observe with what expression and what force K. could recite passages from a poetic work. He was speaking of Aladdin, of the inspired daring in wishing that marks him, of the contrast between this bold confidence of genius and the cautious calculation of reflection. He now quoted Aladdin's words to the spirit, where he commands him to build the splendid palace for the wedding night. We were just then walking outside Charlottenborg. K. stopped as he recited these lines, which he accompanied with a slight gesture of the arm. Color came into his cheeks, [351] and his gaze grew bright and warm, and his voice, though subdued, was that of a ruler who knows that he has the power to command.

19.

Once we were talking about Hegel's presentation of the history of philosophy. K. stressed how subjective its interpretation was on many points, and said: "geniuses really always lack the ability to grasp other people's thoughts objectively; everywhere they find their own." — Not long afterwards, in a conversation with me, he happened to say of himself: "I have never had this ability to grasp others objectively." — At that moment he hardly remembered the remark in our earlier conversation; I remembered it, and smiled to myself as I drew the conclusion from his remark about himself.

20.

At the time when Adler's mental derangement was beginning, K. told me a couple of curious incidents about Mag. Adler. Adler came to K. one day with a work he had published and talked with him at some length about the religious authorship of them both. Adler gave K. to understand that he regarded him as a kind of John the Baptist in relation to himself, who, as the one who had received a direct revelation, was the real Messiah. I still remember the smile with which K. told me that he had answered Adler that he was perfectly content with the position Adler assigned him: he found that it was a very respectable function to be a John the Baptist, and he did not aspire to be the Messiah. During the same visit Adler read aloud a large part of his work to K., some of it in his ordinary voice, some in a peculiar whispering one. K. permitted himself a remark to the effect that he could find no new revelation in Adler's work, whereupon Adler said [352]

to him: "Then I will come to you again this evening and read the whole work to you in *this* voice (the whispering one), and then you will see that it will dawn on you." When he told me the story, K. was much amused at this notion of Adler's that varying the voice would make the work more significant. — I once heard a remark about Kierkegaard from Adler in my first year as a student. He spoke of K.'s brilliant conversation, but put forward the opinion that K. sometimes prepared himself for his conversations.

21.

As a younger man, and perhaps even after his dissertation, K. had thought of the possibility of a post at the University. This thought, however, soon receded. He once told me that Sibbern had urged him to apply for an appointment as Docent in philosophy. K. had replied that he would then at any rate have to stipulate a couple of years' time for preparation. "Oh! how can you think that they will appoint you on those terms?" said Sibbern then. "Well, I could of course also," retorted K., "do as Rasmus Nielsen did, and get myself appointed without being prepared." — Sibbern grew cross and said: "You always have to go pecking at Nielsen like that!" — It was a short time after Nielsen had been appointed to the University. —

.....

22.

In various of his writings K. has expressed himself on The Corsair's attack on him. There he has viewed the matter essentially from an ethical standpoint, and, as regards the significance the Corsair attacks had for the general consciousness, he no doubt greatly [353] overestimated it. K. did not have, in relation to a given phenomenon, a sense of reality, if I may use this expression, that could form a counterweight to his so enormously developed reflection. He could, as it were, reflect a trifle up into something of world-historical importance. So, no doubt, it went with him in the case of The Corsair. — In a conversation with me he spoke of the whole tendency of The Corsair and judged its wit-mongering from a purely aesthetic standpoint. His chief complaint against it was that it destroyed the public's sense for the comic in its ideality by always attaching the laughter to particular well-known persons who had once and for all been fixed for its readers as comic figures, so that the reader laughed at what was said, not because it really contained any comic substance, but because, without being really comic, it was said of persons whom people had once and for all agreed to find comic and to laugh at.

23.

Something like what happened to K. with *The Corsair's* attack happened to him also with "Søren Kirk" in Hostrup's "Genboerne." In his posthumous journals K. has touched rather often on the fact that Hostrup put him on the stage, and he has done so in a way that shows that he felt affected by it. I played this role at the play's first performance, and I remember having spoken with K. about it at the time without being able to notice that he attached any importance to it; but in time he no doubt reflected himself into a different mood. In the little role Hostrup took motifs from S. K.'s writings, but in the role he was evidently thinking chiefly of the kind of dialectic that was rampant among the young students in those years, after had given the impulse to a very superficial preoccupation with philosophy. In this kind of dialectic K. was a master in his younger years — when he wanted to be. — My conversation with K. about the role took place [354] one evening when I was going to a rehearsal at Hofteatret. On Højbroplads I met K., who stopped me and asked where I was going. I told him I was going to the rehearsal of Hostrup's play. "Ah yes, you're to play me, of course!" K. said then. I answered him that I was not exactly going to play *him*, but a dialectician of our homegrown kind. We then parted without my detecting that K. disliked my having taken on the little role. In any case he must also have known my relation to him well enough to know that it could never occur to me to put him in a comic light by copying him. For that I had too much devotion to him, and — for that I was much too poor an actor.

24.

In the early forties K. made a journey over to the west coast of Jutland, to his father's native district. He told me a small characteristic incident from this journey. In his native village, for which his late father had founded a sizable endowment for a school, he had been received with great deference, and the schoolmaster in particular had been very busy in his official capacity. "I was really afraid they would put up triumphal arches for me," he said. When he was to leave, he drove past the school. There stood the schoolmaster, drawn up with all the schoolchildren, who were to sing a song composed by the teacher in S. K.'s honor. The teacher, who was to lead the singing, stood with a copy in his hand and was just about to give the sign to begin when K.'s carriage stopped beside him. S. K. leaned down, with his friendliest smile, toward the schoolmaster, took the copy out of his hand, as if to read it through, and at the same moment gave the coachman a sign to drive on. With that the whole arrangement fell to pieces. The parish clerk, who did not know his poem by heart, could not get the song started, the children

[355] stood silent and astonished, and S. K. rolled off down the highway, nodding and greeting, and in his heart amused at the schoolmaster's disappointment.

25.

On the day that Licentiat Hagen (later Professor of theology) had defended his dissertation, I talked with K. about the dissertation ("Om Ægteskabet"), against which I had been an opponent. K. was little pleased with it; he found the whole treatment superficial, and he alluded to what is offered by the pseudonyms toward a fuller conception. On this occasion too he stressed the Germans' more thorough treatment of such subjects, and said with regard to Hagen's treatise: "one really should see to it that we can cut a somewhat decent figure when such books are read by the Germans."

26.

While I was staying in Berlin in the summer of 1846, S. K. came there. It was one of the little journeys he sometimes made when he really wanted to work intensively and sought changed surroundings in order to put himself in the mood. I met him quite unexpectedly at the restaurant where I ate, and where he had gone chiefly to see fellow countrymen, since during his first stay in Berlin this restaurant had been the gathering place of the Danes. As a restaurant he did not think much of it; it confined itself, he remarked, to "the lowest concept of foddering." He met me with much friendliness, invited me to dine with him the next day at the hotel, and took long walks with me during the couple of days he stayed in Berlin. I was much taken up with everything new that I came into contact with in Berlin, and was tirelessly active. K. was amused at this activity, which extended even to my attending the meetings of a democratic [356] workers' association. We talked a great deal together about conditions in Berlin, about conditions at home, about my dissertation, etc. On our walks I noticed that there were certain spots for which K. had acquired a fondness and which he liked to seek out. Thus in the Thiergarten there was a pretty spot with a park surrounded by flower beds. It became the goal of his walk, just as the flower beds at the entrance to Frederiksberg Have had been in Copenhagen. Perhaps it awakened memories in him of that garden and of what was connected with it. — Visiting him at the hotel, I noticed with what ingenious calculation everything in his room was arranged so that he could work in the right mood. The lighting, the connection between the rooms, the arrangement of the furniture, everything was ordered according to a definite plan. K. made very great demands on the service, but was also very generous with his gratuities. Our little dinner

for 2 persons was served in his room. We drank a wine that he was fond of because of its name: Liebfrauenmilch. This name had given him the impression of something mild and light, and he drank the wine in good faith, trusting this impression, without noticing that it is in fact one of the headier Rhine wines. — It did me good to meet K. in that foreign place. He confirmed me in what I was then beginning to think about again: returning to Denmark and trying to make my way there. — From Berlin I once sent K., who was always amused by the Berliners' Ueberschwänglichkeit, through our cousin, Mrs. T., an advertisement I had found in a Berlin advertising gazette. It read, under the heading: Anfrage, as follows: "Sollte es nicht zweckmässig sein das auch die Klempner sich assoziirten, um mit dem Zeitgeiste Schritt zu halten?" — It amused Kierkegaard, who recognized his Pappenheimers.

27.

After I had come home from my first Italian journey (at the end of 1847), K. once [357] came up to me as I stood on Østergade looking at some plaster casts of antique sculptures that stood in the window of the plaster-caster Barsugli. When we came to talk of the art of sculpture, he remarked that he had not really had an eye for it, but that it was now beginning to attract him by its repose. On the whole I do not believe that K.'s interest in and feeling for the visual arts were strongly developed; his interest in the beautiful drew its nourishment overwhelmingly from poetry.

28.

Shortly after the rebellion had broken out in 1848, I talked with K. about the plan I then had of going along as a volunteer. Besides the general motive that lay in the circumstances, I stressed that I personally needed to gain experience, above all experience of myself. K. granted that this way of learning through reality was necessary for many, but intimated that through imagination and reflection he took in, ideally, a still richer content. And it was evidently the case that he could make do with a *motif* from reality, which his reflection and his imagination worked up, guided as they were by the experience he had gathered through the ceaseless labor of his own inner life.

29.

Some years later I talked with K. about a similar subject. At that time I felt dissatisfied at not having a definite occupation, and the definite duties that go with one; the complete freedom I enjoyed in my life of private study, holding no office, was beginning to become

a burden to me. I said so in a conversation with K.: “I miss a definite practical occupation [358] to such a degree that, if no other is to be found, I could be tempted to set myself up as a tavern-keeper.”—K. smiled and said: “Then you shall have my custom.” In that connection he told me how, some years earlier, he had received a visit from a German scholar who had presumably been sent to him by someone or other to look at him as one of our curiosities. He had received the German very politely, but had assured him that there must be some misunderstanding behind the visit. “My brother, the Doctor,” he had said, “is an extraordinarily learned man whom it would surely interest you to get to know, but I am a beer-seller.”

30.

Dr. P. K. once gave—I do not remember the time exactly, but it must have been in the fifties—during a chance stay down here, a series of lectures at the University. They were held in the Solennitetssal before a large and very mixed audience. Søren K. took a rather ironic attitude toward these lectures, and it was with a certain malice that he told me a fragment of a conversation he had overheard one evening outside the University, just as the lecture was beginning. A crowd of gentlemen and still more ladies came streaming up the University steps. The coachman of a carriage waiting outside was addressed by a passing fellow with the question of what all these people were going in there for? “Oh! they’ll be going to a dance, I suppose!” answered the coachman, to S. K.’s great delight. The lectures were in the Doctor’s manner, rather forcedly brilliant, and in a prophetic-apocalyptic style. I was able to tell S. K. an anecdote concerning the lectures, about our old uncle in Købmagergade. He attended the lectures regularly, although they lay far above his horizon and although he was very hard of hearing. He felt exceedingly proud to see his “cousin’s son on Gammeltorv” lecturing to so numerous [359] a crowd. One evening, when he had come home from the lectures, he walked up and down the floor of his parlor, repeating without pause: “No! he really is a matchless man, that Peter Kierkegaard! the way he can talk, the way he can talk.” His daughter ventured the question: “Now, could you really follow his lecture? could you really hear what he said?”—“Not *one* word! not *one* word!” said the old Jutlander guilelessly, but his enthusiasm for the matchless speaker was just as great.

31.

S. K. once told me of a curious situation involving this old uncle. The old uncle had a passion for making verses, equally ghastly in content and form. One day he came up to

see S. K. and, after a little preamble, came out with a pile of his verses, which he asked his nephew to read aloud. They then took their places side by side on the sofa. The old man sat leaning back and put on his spectacles so as to follow along during the reading, most likely in order to make sure that nothing was skipped. Søren K. sat somewhat bent forward, with the papers, and presumably chose this position so that the old man should not observe a treacherous smile on his face. He read the poems aloud from one end to the other in a raised voice and with great pathos. The old man was utterly enraptured; the tears ran down his cheeks from emotion at the beautiful verses, and he left S. K. with the warmest thanks.— Old Uncle's verses I have often heard; they were altogether remarkable, and had in particular the wonderful property of being usable, or at any rate of being used, with very slight variations, on the most heterogeneous occasions. Thus the old man had once, on the occasion of a granddaughter's engagement, composed a verse. It was then used not only at another engagement, where the personal circumstances of those concerned were, after all, very different; but with a quite trifling adjustment it was [360] also to have been used on the occasion of my appointment to the University. That it was not was owing only to the old man's not having got it rearranged on the evening when the appointment, a little earlier than we had expected, was announced by Berlingske, and we happened to be at a party at the old man's.—Sometimes the verses were sung by the company at his house at his urgent request. A tune would then be chosen which by a Procrustean method could more or less be applied to them; but it was irresistibly comic to hear how now a large number of syllables had to be taken, as it were, in one mouthful, now a single syllable drawn out according to the Holbergian prescription. But to the old man's ears it always sounded like the loveliest harmonies; his face beamed with rapture at it.

32.

Old Kierkegaard sometimes used, in speech and in writing, though chiefly in writing, peculiar orders of words. Thus, when in his letters to his native town he spoke of S. K. and his brother, he used always to write: "my cousin's late son Peter K., or: my cousin's late son S. K." (instead of: my late cousin's son). It looked especially comic in one context: when he reported that his cousin's late son, Peter Kierkegaard, had taken himself a new wife. I once told S. K. of this way of putting things on the uncle's part. It amused him, but for his own part he read into it a meaning of which the old man was unconscious (the old man was, after all, inspired, as a poet!): that he was in reality one of the departed.—On the same occasion he came to speak of the uncle's great age. I said that in a certain sense one could not call him old, if, that is, one measured the length of life by its content,

[361] since the old man in reality only “lived” the smallest part of the time he existed, and for the most part merely vegetated and slept. I added jokingly that S. K. was really the oldest man I had known. He smiled and made no objection to this way of reckoning.

33.

K. once told me—it occurs to me as I mention his age—that as a young man he had for many years lived in the firm conviction that he would die when he reached the age of 33. (Was it the age of Jesus that was also to be the norm for the imitator of Jesus?)—This belief was so firm in him that, when he passed that age, he even had the parish register looked up in order to make sure that it really had been passed; so hard was it for him to believe this.

34.

When I first lectured at the University, in the winter semester of 1849–50, S. K. talked with me about it fairly often, about the subject of the lectures (Greek philosophy) and about the plan for treating it. He told me that he would come round some time and hear them, but that he would not name any particular hour. He did not come, however; but through that constant prospect of possibly having him as a listener he gave me an impulse to treat my subject with care, and I rather think that that is what he intended. He also knew that, if he really were present, I would easily feel embarrassed by his presence, and that may have been one reason for him to stay away.

35.

In connection with my lectures he once talked with me about the Aristotelian metaphysics’ definition of virtue as μεσότης. He had rightly seen that this definition did not [362] apply to virtue in general, but only to ethical virtue—something on which people at that time were by no means clear. He told me that, in connection with this point and some others in the Nicomachean Ethics, he had sought information from Madvig and Sibbern. Madvig had told him that it was so long since he had read this work that he no longer had it present to mind. “And Madvig is otherwise a formidable man,” S. K. added. Sibbern, on the other hand, had at once been able to give him the information he sought. S. K. thought highly of S., even if he was not blind to his weaknesses. Among these he once singled out Sibbern’s complete lack of irony and—in psychological respects—his lack of an eye for the masked passions, for the doubling by which one passion takes on the form of another. Because of this, in his opinion, Sibbern had often been deceived at a time

when many, especially ladies, turned to him to consult him as a kind of psychological counselor of souls.

36.

Poul Møller was someone S. K. often came to speak of, always with the most heartfelt affection. It was Poul Møller's personality, far more than his writings, that had made an impression on him, and he regretted that a time would soon come when, once the preserved memory of his personality had vanished and judgment of him rested only on his writings, people would no longer be able to understand his significance. He once told me an amusing little anecdote of P. Møller. He was to oppose *ex officio* at a disputation and had noted down his remarks on various loose sheets which had been laid inside the dissertation. Each separate objection he introduced with a "*graviter vituperandum est*"; but as soon as the *Præses* had given an answer to the objection, he would say very good-naturedly: *Concedo*, and pass on to the next objection. After a rather short opposition he closed with a lively expression of regret that his time did not permit him [363] to continue this interesting conversation, and as he then withdrew and passed S. K., who stood among the audience, he said to him in an undertone: "Shall we go down to *Pleisch's*, then?"—that was the confectioner's where he used to go.—During the opposition it had happened to him that all his loose papers had at once fallen out of the book and fluttered about on the floor, and it had contributed not a little to raising the mood of the audience to see that large figure crawling about to gather up the scattered sheets.

37.

A man with whom in those years I regularly saw K. walking was Professor Kolderup-Rosenvinge. It was chiefly a shared interest in the aesthetic that brought them into contact. K.-R. was a cultivated man who occupied himself with the literatures of southern Europe and had translated a play by Calderon. For the rest, he was by then already rather dulled, and in many respects extremely narrow-minded. When I once expressed to S. K. my astonishment that he could find it interesting to talk with Rosenvinge, he stressed his general cultivation. In general he set great store by people of the older generation who had preserved the humane interests of an earlier time and that refinement of manner which a younger generation so much lacked.

38.

With the late Pastor Spang K. had for a time (in the years 1844–45?) associated a great deal, and had almost daily called for Spang at his home for a longish evening walk. (Several interesting letters to Spang from S. K. are in the possession of Spang's daughter, Mrs. Rump). After Spang had died, K. once told me how his widow had been [364] overwhelmed with grief, and how he had, by his conversation, helped to bring her mind back into balance. On that occasion he used the expression: "I know how one should grieve, and how one should comfort in grief." And indeed: he understood it as few do. He comforted, not by covering up the grief, but by first bringing it properly to consciousness, clearing it up completely, and then reminding one that it was a *duty* to grieve, but for that very reason also a duty not to let oneself be crushed by grief, but in grief to preserve the strength for one's work, indeed to find in grief the incentive to do that work still more fully.—I have myself, in my relationship with S. K., more than once had the experience of how he knew how to lift one up when one was bowed down, to comfort when one grieved, and that without one's needing to speak of what was oppressing or saddening one. Thus I remember how once, in the autumn of 1850, when, because I had not been able to find lodgings in time, I had to stay for a short while at a cheerless inn, and under the impression of my surroundings despondent thoughts had got the upper hand, I then one evening, as I was walking dejectedly in the street, met K., who began a conversation with me. Without my needing to say a word about myself, he saw with his sharp eye that I needed to be brought out of an oppressive mood, and he knew how, by his conversation, without its seeming for a moment to be directly aimed at that, so to free my mind that I left him glad and in good heart, and for a long time was freed from the power of melancholy.

39.

Much of what S. K. worked out in his writings I remember him touching on in conversation with me while his thought was at work on it, and precisely because it was still in the making, it had a life and an attraction even greater than what it could [365] have when fully formed. Thus I remember that once, while he was walking along with Christens and me, he developed the theme he so often has treated in his upbuilding writings, that "the *whole* of life is the time of trial." He developed it in this form: that for the believer there was an "At last" which seemed to be so near that it could be grasped, but constantly drew back, until the end of life finally led to grasping it. Only in death could it be said: "At last!"—Sometimes in his conversations S. K. expressed his thought in a more pointed, more paradoxical form than in his writings. It amused him to formulate it so that it formed the opposite of something commonly accepted. Thus, in opposition to

the maxim: experience makes one wise, he used to put forward the theory: "Experience makes one mad!" and he could carry out the proof with much humor by pointing to all the countless contradictions of concrete experience.

40.

The different direction of our spiritual lives and our fundamentally different relation to what is Christian came now and then distinctly to light when we talked together. Once, probably in 1851, he asked me what I was occupied with at the moment. I answered him that I was reading the N. T. That seemed to please him, but it did not please him when I added that I was reading it chiefly with the aim of finding, in what has been handed down, what is primitively Christian, and of following the successive development of Christian dogmatic ideas. For him such an investigation was something almost offensive. Although he draws the dogmas into his writings so little, and everywhere keeps to what is central in Christianity, he could not, for all that, place himself in such a relation to Scripture that it became the object of a critical investigation. He could not do so, partly because Scripture stood for him as a unity, as the unified expression of what is Christian, into which he would bring no distinction; partly because, by being made the object of a [366] scientific investigation, it became an object of knowledge instead of an object of faith.

41.

My divergence from S. K. in relation to what is Christian I did not hide from him; but we did not dispute about it. There was so extraordinarily much in which we could be in sympathy, and I preferred to let myself be taught by him about much that was of great importance to me, rather than carry on a discussion in which, by his superiority, he could easily have overwhelmed me, but not easily convinced me. In our conversations, too, his attitude toward me was essentially communicative, and I saw in this a proof that he bore me goodwill. He had two ways of conversing: the one essentially communicative, awakening, encouraging; the other questioning, ironizing, and, through his dialectic, confounding. The latter he never used against me. Once in a while, when I grew heated, he might throw in a joking, teasing word. Thus I was once speaking very heatedly about how no positive religion could be tolerant, precisely because, by its claim to be revealed religion, it had to lay claim to being the only true one, and therefore had to posit the others as untrue. Something universally religious, a "religion in general," must therefore, from the standpoint of positive religion, be an absurdity. As I was developing this with heat, I happened to repeat the expression: a religion in general, and made my own the

proposition that a religion (i.e. *positive* religion) in general was an absurdity.—“Yes, and a chamber pot over the head,” said K., and thereby damped my ardor. That is, however, the only piece of teasing of that kind I remember from him.—If he never tried to counter my divergent views directly, I can, given the whole friendly sympathy he always showed [367] me, and which I gratefully remember, only seek the reason for it in this, that he knew that I was occupying myself honestly and earnestly with the cause that was for him the highest, and that I was so familiar with what he had written about it, and with his whole way of thinking, that I had sufficient premises for a conclusion, and would not be brought nearer to it by another, but in any case only by myself.

42.

Concerning the general effect of S. K.’s writings I once said something to him that seemed to make some impression on him. He was speaking of how, as an author, he had had the peculiar fate of publishing one work after another without calling forth any real criticism, whether hostile or approving. He then told me that his writings had nevertheless found a circle of readers from the beginning, and, it seemed, a fixed circle, since the number of copies sold straight away was roughly the same (c. 70 for the writings that followed *Either/Or*). I expressed my conviction that a great many people read his writings with real seriousness, and that the silence of our press, which I explained chiefly by the critics’ feeling that the writings lay beyond the powers of their criticism, was by no means a sign that he was meeting with indifference in a wider public, on which I believed that he was, precisely, already then having an effect on a large scale. But I added that the effect, as regards the relation to Christianity, had in my opinion been as much negative as positive. All those on whom the writings had had an effect, in the one direction or the other, were surely agreed that only in his conception did Christianity have a real distinctiveness and inspire reverence. But his definition of [368] Christianity was such that it must, precisely, have the power to drive many away from it, as was the case with me, and must have it precisely through the separation it set between Christianity and nature and concrete human life. — We were, when I said these words to K., just in the act of taking leave of each other; he grew serious and silently gave me his hand, and parted from me, but with a friendly expression on his face.

43.

S. K. spoke without reserve of the significance his writings could have for certain particular persons. His old uncle, the wholesale merchant M. Kierkegaard, had a son,

a couple of years younger than S. K., who was disabled, paralyzed down the whole of one side, and wholly a cripple; spiritually, on the other hand, well gifted. He read his cousin's writings with the greatest interest, visited him now and then at his home, and drew from these visits much spiritual uplift. I once talked about him with S. K. and told him how great an impression one of his works, the confessional discourse in "Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits", had made on him. In it there is a passage about a person who by his bodily weakness is prevented from carrying on any work in the outward world, and it is depicted beautifully and upliftingly how such a person too has the universally human ethical task undiminished, and what particular form the task of life takes for him. S. K. said: "Yes! for him this book is a blessing." And so it truly was. It had the power to give the sorely tried man strength to overcome the thought that his existence was useless and wasted, and to give him the consciousness of being essentially the equal of those more happily endowed by nature. Precisely this consciousness S. K. also knew how to call to life in him by his conversations; that is why he came away from them so strengthened.

44.

[369]

A conversation that I have often remembered since, I had with S. K. some time before his "Practice in Christianity" came out. We were walking together down by the Lakes, and he urged me not to put it off too long, beginning an authorship. He added jokingly: "Now, you know, there is a place vacant in our literature; *now I am finished*." This remark, which I passed over lightly at the time, came back vividly to my memory later, when the last section of S. K.'s authorship lay completed. When he spoke to me in this way, he evidently still cherished the hope of being able to avoid the last battle with the established order. Had that battle not been forced upon him, his authorship would indeed have been — essentially ended, concluded, when that conversation took place. In reality all the stages that were to be traversed had by then been traversed; his writings formed a wonderfully complete whole. But the next stage still bore within it a possibility of a redoubling, and this possibility became actuality when an attempt was made to reduce his conception of Christianity to an eccentric exaggeration, to set up mediocrity and spiritlessness as what is properly normal.

45.

In the same conversation S. K. came to single out one aspect of his authorship, which he spoke of with the objectivity peculiar to him: it was the significance of his writings for

Danish prose. He said: "In this century our literature has displayed an almost abnormal wealth in the development of its poetry; our prose literature, on the other hand, has lagged behind; we lacked a prose that bore the stamp of the artistic. This lack I have filled, and that significance my writings will also retain for our literature." In this I believe [370] he is right: his prose is art, not without its shadows, but as a whole the clearest, most supple, most comprehensive and fullest expression for thought, and no less for feeling and passion, that our literature knows. It has often reminded me of Plato, the author with whose prose I would most readily compare Kierkegaard's, and who has surely also given him the model, which he has freely made over in his own way.

46.

In his writings S. K. has in several places spoken of Grundtvig and Grundtvigianism, and almost everywhere seen it from the comic side. In a similar way he often expressed himself about it in his conversations. The sharp contrast between his conception of the religious and the Grundtvigian one constantly came out, and the Grundtvigian childish immediacy was cast in a comic light by the contrast. Only about one period of Grundtvig's life did S. K. once speak to me with interest and appreciation: it was the time when Gr. came out against Clausen. But what appealed to K. in his conduct then was evidently not the specifically Grundtvigian, least of all the "matchless discovery", which always seemed to K. a matchless piece of foolishness, and an unoriginal piece of foolishness at that, but what forms the opposite of rationalism: the religious stirring of *life*. S. K.'s father, whose religious orientation was closest to that of the old Pietism, sympathized with Grundtvig and Lindberg, surely from this point of view, and S. K.'s sympathy undoubtedly had the same motive and the same limits as his father's.

47.

A little trait of S. K.'s comes to mind as I think of Grundtvig. The patroness of Grundtvigianism, the Queen Dowager Caroline Amalie, also thought highly of S. K., at least before his attack on Mynster. S. K. was evidently not insensible to goodwill [371] shown him by a queen. One day I was walking with him on Kærlighedsstien, when he suddenly burst out: "Well, devil take it! now I shan't get away." I looked at him in surprise, for otherwise he never used words resembling an oath, and looked ahead along the path, where a long way off I caught sight of a footman in red livery, and in front of him two ladies. One of these was the Queen Dowager, who, when we met her, very graciously stopped S. K. and talked with him. When he saw her, we were so far from her

that we could easily have turned back without having been noticed. That his outburst was not altogether sincerely meant was the impression I got from this: "well, devil take it!" was not like him, and it came out somewhat forced, as when one wants by a strong expression to hide that one is really quite pleased that something is happening. S. K.'s old, traditional reverence for the royal power has not been without significance in his relation to the Queen Dowager.

48.

About Bishop Mynster I had, in the spring of 1852, a conversation with S. K. that I often could not help thinking of later, when K. came out against him. One afternoon I was walking on the Ramparts, on the promenade that runs along the top of the parapet, and there I passed Bishop Mynster. A moment later I met S. K., who was walking below on the Ramparts and called to me. He had seen Mynster walking ahead of him, and so our conversation turned to him. K. first spoke of his imposing and venerable appearance, and then of his shrewd and polished manner, and how as a man of the world he was superior to most of the younger men, who for a time had believed that with their philosophical apparatus they could treat Mynster as a subordinate figure, but soon, on personal contact with him, had been overwhelmed by him and now subordinated themselves to him. He named in particular as one who by his awkwardness and lack of polish gave Mynster so high a degree of superiority in their personal dealings. But he stressed very [372] strongly that Mynster's forte was precisely his worldly wisdom, and that it was this that determined his conduct. Of his own relation to Mynster K. spoke ironically. He told me with a smile that he had once asked Mynster's permission, whenever there were problems that he could not himself bring to clarity, to seek guidance then from His Right Reverend Excellency! and that Mynster had kindly given him this permission. The smile alone with which he told me this showed me clearly how little, in reality, he thought of Mynster at that time, and the whole manner in which he characterized Mynster as a man of the world agreed perfectly with his later pronouncements. There was a time when he had thought very highly of Mynster, and he had come to this essentially through filial piety toward his father, who valued Mynster greatly. This dutiful regard for his father's judgment I have seen in several cases determining K.'s view. Thus I remember that he once spoke with much goodwill of a man who in no respect deserved esteem or could by his person have aroused S. K.'s interest; but his father felt great attachment and gratitude toward this man, who had once, by a shrewd piece of advice, prevented his financial affairs, which were endangered in the confused monetary period after the war with England, from falling into disorder.

49.

When S. K. began his polemic against the established order, and perhaps some time before that, he stopped taking part in the public worship of the Church, at which he had previously been a very regular attendant. The late Dr. Frederik Beck once told me that in that period S. K. liked to come into the Athenæum on Sunday mornings during church time; which Beck, with the relish for barbed remarks peculiar to him, interpreted [373] to mean that S. K. wanted to make people notice that he did not go to church. — Once, many years earlier, S. K. had asked me whether I went to church. I said no, and told him that I did not, partly because I felt a stranger there, partly because the service in the Copenhagen churches went on amid so many disturbances that I could in no case keep a devout frame of mind, but was more likely to be driven to take offense. He then said that it was a *duty* not to let oneself be disturbed by what went on around one; one *should* be upbuilt when one was in church.

50.

The last time I spoke with S. K. was in the summer of 1855, when I had not seen him for an unusually long time. It was one evening as I was walking from Højbroplads up toward Vimmelskaftet. K. came up to me and began a conversation. After we had talked for a moment about my brief part in political life (in the winter of 1854–55 I had been a member of the Rigsdag), we soon came to speak of his polemic against the established order of the Church. I thanked him warmly for his stand, and told him how many I had found who sympathized with him wholeheartedly. He spoke of the situation he had brought about with the greatest clarity and calm, and it astonished me that in the midst of the violent struggle, which cut so deep into his life and laid claim to his last strength, he could preserve not only his wonted composure and confidence, but could still keep his sense of fun. As we were nearing his home — at that time he lived in Klædeboderne — he said in a joking tone: “Now I’ll go home and go to bed, and then I’ll say to the world what that Kammerraad said.” I asked him what, then, this Kammerraad had said. He then told me that there had once lived an eccentric there in the street, who [374] was a Kammerraad by title, and who regularly every evening used to hold the following conversation with the watchman. When the watchman had called ten, the Kammerraad would open the window and ask: “Watchman, what time is it now?” — “It is ten o’clock, Mr. Kammerraad.” — “Good! then I think I’ll go to bed. If anyone should ask for me now, watchman, you may tell them to —” (Götz v. Berlichingen’s answer.) — He told this story with his old humor, and I bade him Good night! without suspecting that I had that evening spoken with him for the last time.

(Written between 27 Dec. 1871 and 10 January 1872.)

H. Brøchner.